



Other cone-bearing trees



Cycads Sometimes living for 1,000 years, these slow-growing, palmlike plants develop structures called strobili, which are similar to conifer cones.



Welwitschia Found only in the Namib Desert in Africa, these plants are either male or female. Although not true conifers, the females have seed-bearing cones.



Ginkgo These trees are either male or female. The males have pollen-bearing cones, but the females produce seeds that swell up to look like the fruits of flowering trees.

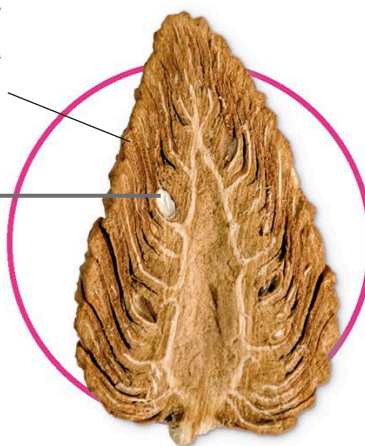


Open Austrian pine cone

Open cone scales > When the seeds inside a cone are ready, dry weather triggers the cones to open up or even fall off the tree, so the wind can blow the seeds away.

Tough, woody scales grow all around the cone. They open slightly to allow fertilization and then close again to protect the developing seeds.

Cross section of a female cone



Seed > Conifer seeds can take up to two years to mature. They are attached to thin scales that act like wings, allowing the seeds to be carried away in the wind when the time is right.



Winged seed